

Encounter design

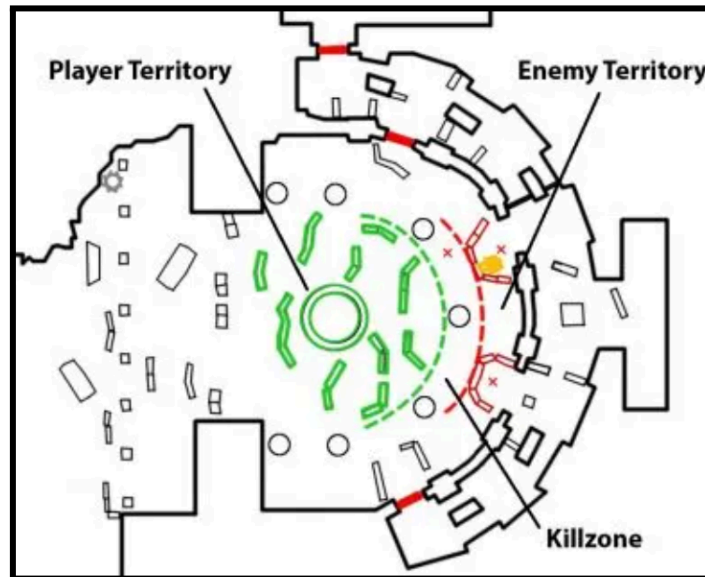
Analysis and considerations

These are considerations on encounter design from a level design perspective. First an overview on what a combat zone, or an encounter, is supposed to have and how it's composed.

Then I'll analyze three games (Hades, Curse of the Dead Gods and Death's Door) based on the previous arguments.

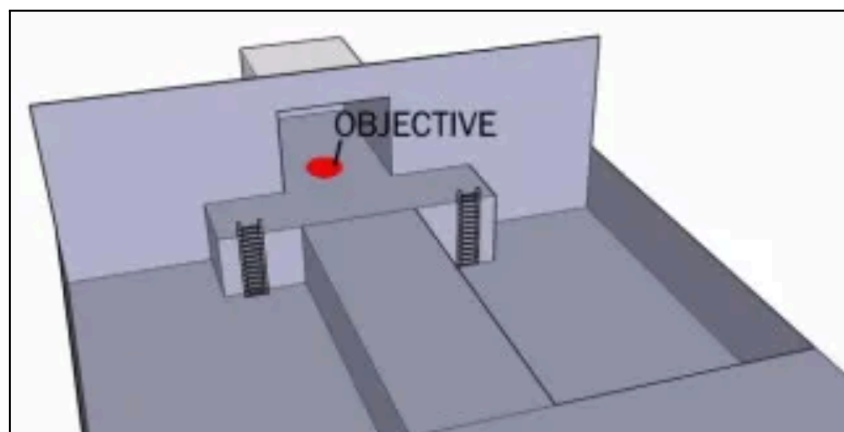
Components of a combat zone:

- **Player zone:** The place occupied by the player when the fight starts. Should contain a generous amount of covers and is relatively safe to move within and has time to think. The number of covers and the width of the general space can challenge the player even in its zone.
- **Enemy zone:** The place occupied by the enemy when the fight starts. Parts of it might be obscured or too far for the player to see. Usually has less cover options than the Player zone.
- **Player front:** The furthest point forward of the Player zone. Surpassing that the player might get in danger.
- **Enemy front:** Equivalent of the Player front, but for the enemies.
- **Killzone:** The territory between the two fronts. It defines the two zones and has very little or no covers at all. The player (or AI) that enters this zone, will probably be killed or heavily injured. It's the difficulty the player has to overcome to win the battle.
- **Flank routes:** One of the solutions to overcome the Killzone. A path that circumvents the danger of the Killzone and links the Player and Enemy zones. Provides an advantageous point of attack, from behind or on the side of the enemies.
- **Covers:** They provide security from an attack and their number and positioning can depend on where they are placed.
 - They can be:
 - **Fixed:** Can't be moved and can't be destructed
 - **Destructible:** Riskier, forces the player to engage in direct combat or to flee.
 - Can vary on:
 - **Amount:** More means more protection and more opportunity to move. Less results in a larger and deadlier Killzone.
 - **Spacing:** Is the player able to reach it with a roll? Or does it have to roll and then run? Cover connected facilitated movements.
 - **Size:** Larger covers provide a more secure protection
 - **Density:** A cluster of trees or lamppost break sight lines, but not shots fired

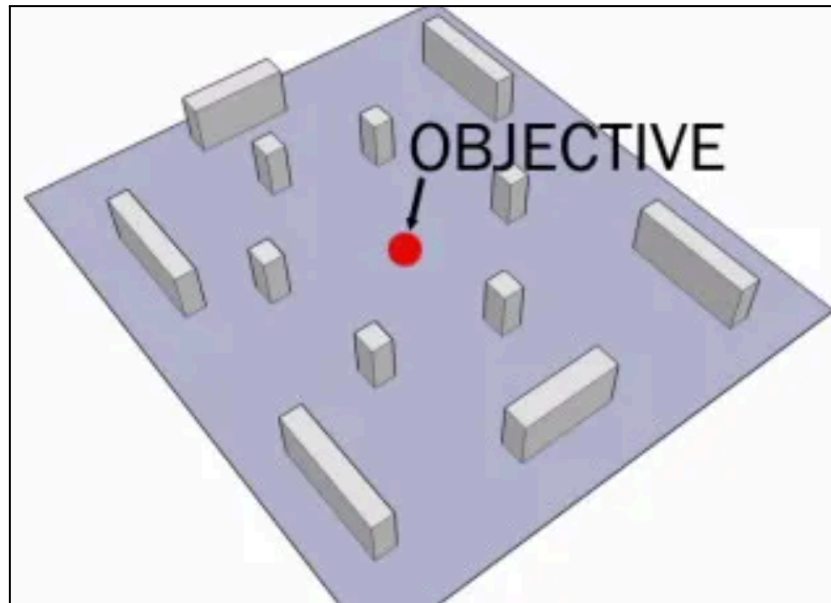


Layering, positioning and tooltips (to avoid repetition):

- **Different ways of playing.** One may prefer to run while shooting all their bullets with a shotgun, others might prefer to stay as far as possible and shoot with the sniper rifle. To design an encounter for everyone is hard, but the playstyle must be taken into account when creating the layout.
- **Enemy placement:** Enemies behind covers or using long-range weapons will provide a greater challenge. Using different enemies, spread out in the encounter can be too much depending on how they are used. Too many different enemies means that the player will have to think about every possible action every kind of enemy might have. This is why most games will let the player face 3-4 different enemies at most at the same time.
 - The path to the exit, or to progress, should lead the player to the enemies, encouraging them to go across and face them.
- **Risk and reward:** Pretty straight forward. Having the possibility to shoot a pile of dynamite to kill all the enemies can make the player feel powerful. Achieving that shouldn't be that easy, giving the player a choice. Risk for a reward, or stay safe.
- **Layouts:** There are two major layout in combat areas:
 - **Bottlenecks:** A path (or more) will lead to a point (called choke point) the player has to cross. That point is the Killzone that has to be overcome.



- **Freeform:** The choke point isn't explicit. The result is a more free Killzone and depends heavily on how and where the player approaches.



- **Reverse positioning:** After having conquered a position, the player might have to defend it from incoming enemies. It reuses the same layout but reversing the situation, making it feel different.
 - **High ground:** The player first was at disadvantage having to conquer a higher ground. Now he has the advantage, as a reward for completing the previous "mission". The opposite can be used to challenge the player.
 - **Covers:** The enemy zone should have less covers to help the players in their mission. Now that the situation is reversed, they will have to handle less covers and more protected enemies.

Competitors

Rooms and connections

Hades and **Curse of the Dead gods**(CDG from now on) have similar features in their dungeons, most likely due to their procedural nature. Even if the rooms are premade in Hades, their generation and position is randomized.

Death's Door on the other hand has everything designed, and shares fewer features with the other two games.

In Hades **every room is separated** from the next one with a gate, accessible only when all enemies are defeated and once the player surpasses it they can't go back.

CDG has more rooms on a single floor, but each encounter room has a **gate** that locks the player in and doesn't allow them to go back, forcing them to face the enemies. It also closes the gate to the next room, preventing **unwanted enemies from joining** the fight.

The exploration in **Death's Door** is more free and the player can go back and forth as much as he likes. The only exception is when there is an encounter room and the player is locked inside until all enemies are defeated.

Obstructions and traps

While Death's Door combat zones are flat and almost empty, the ones in Hades and CDG have similar features like traps, obstructions and unnatural shapes.

Traps

- Only the player can activate them
- They hurt both the player and the enemies
- Can be activated multiple times

The major difference is that in Hades once the encounter is completed, they **can't be activated** anymore and the player is free to move around the room without risking getting hurt.

In CDG the **traps remain active**, probably due to the fact that even if the room is completed, there is potentially more exploration to do. Having functioning traps means a more alive (and dangerous) world and **suggests the player to remain vigilant**, for the threats are not over yet.

Obstructions

Obstacles and covers are both included here.

- Can be destroyed
- Can damage the enemies
- They remain destroyed
- Block enemy and player attacks
- Some are indestructible

Obstructions have more **depth** than just cover or obstacles. In Hades can be used to hurt the enemies, while in CDG the braziers also serve as a source of light, preventing more damage from being in the dark or from invisible traps.

Interesting to note that some rooms are just **trap rooms** without enemies.

Paths and loot

Loot and resources that can be found in a room/floor:

- For the run
 - Food/Health
 - Gold
 - Weapons (in CDG)
- To spend in the HUB
 - Currency to improve character (Darkness or Skulls)
 - Currency to improve HUB
 - Keys
 - Gems
 - Ambrosia

Side paths (in CDG, for Hades has none) are always **dead-ended**, and the path to progress is always one. Often is clear on where to progress, shown by a door or by a less ruined path.

Shops are also present in some rooms, as a unique type of room or as an alternative reward when all enemies are defeated.

Conclusions

Being a game heavily **based on ranged combat**, forts in Dino Path should have wide rooms and covers for a regular/easy encounter, while narrow corridors or few covers to challenge.

A **gate** to force the player to fight/avoid unwanted enemies to join the fight might be useful and help better design an encounter.

Bottlenecks layout serves better this purpose, while freeform layout can be used in an open space giving greater freedom of movement to the player.

Traps are an interesting feature, with the limitation of having to be **contextualized** in a fort/wild west setting. Being an "open" map (the player can roam free and is not limited by one room at the time) they should remain **activatable** even after the encounter is concluded.

Resources are very important. There is no auto-heal like in Hades and no checkpoints like in Death's Door, plus the player has to deal with hunger and thirst **adding another layer of difficulty** to the map (rather than the encounter itself).

The player should find plenty of food and water, because a fort should not be the map where you'd risk starving.

Bandages can be dropped/found in the map, but dying because of the enemies should be a concern for the player.

Variation to the encounters can be provided with **positioning** (of enemies, of the player and of the covers), **number** and **kind** of enemies and covers. An interesting idea is to utilize the **same room for different encounters**, giving the player different entrances and forcing them to fight in different spots.

The idea of giving the player a powerful weapon, or an easier way of killing the enemies like dynamite, can be done but with an **associated risk**, giving the player the possibility to choose between a safer or a riskier route.

There can be side paths, but should **not diverge too much** from the main one to not let the player waste too much time (same reasoning as before: starving) and to let them have a clear idea on where to go to progress.

